rural areas. The bank's plans for 1972–73 envisaged the opening of 650 new offices but it was able to open only 531 due to non-availability of office premises and accommodation for staff in remote areas. By the end of 1973, the bank had 3,015 offices of which three-fourths were in rural or semi-urban areas. In December 1973, it opened its 3,000th branch in Rayagada in the Koraput district of Orissa. In the years 1974–76, the pace of expansion accelerated greatly and more branches were opened that those planned for. In 1974, the bank opened 375 against the target of 368; in 1975, 419 compared to a target of 414; and in 1976, 443 against a target of 430.

THE NAGARWALA EPISODE

A *cause célèbre* during the Bangladesh War in 1971 was the Nagarwala episode. On May 24, 1971, Rustom Sohrab Nagarwala conned the Parliament Street branch of the SBI of ₹60 lakhs by mimicking the voice of Prime Minister Indira Gandhi. Nagarwala told the Chief Cashier, V.P. Malhotra, that ₹60 lakhs in cash was required for a secret mission and that this cash should be delivered immediately in accordance with the instructions given to him. Malhotra was asked to bring the amount in notes of ₹100 and deliver the money to a point close to a certain church. He was also given a password for identification. Malhotra was overwhelmed by what he thought was a direct call from the Prime Minister and rushed to do her bidding.

He went to the Branch Accountant and asked him to open the strong room and withdraw the cash telling him that the payment would be regularized later. Malhotra then took the money in a vehicle from the bank's pool, drove to the appointed place and delivered the cash. Nagarwala asked him to drive to the airport where he claimed an Indian Air Force aircraft was waiting for the money. However, he changed his mind and took the cash in a taxi. Malhotra then rushed to the Prime Minister's residence to tell her that he had done her bidding. This was when the con came to light. P.N. Haksar who was the Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister told him that he was the victim of a dupe. Luckily, Malhotra remembered the number of the taxi in which the cash was spirited away and reported the matter to the police. The money was finally traced to a *dharamsala* in New Delhi and the